



CHASING Sleep

Tired all the time, nodding off in the afternoons, snoring at nights. Sounds like you? Better check out. Experts say, millions of Indians need to catch up with their sleep.

How to sleep right and enough

■ By Stephen David

Sleeping next to a man snoring through the night is bad enough. But when one night his wife noticed a lull in his snoring and realised he had stopped breathing, she dragged him to a sleep clinic, where they attached a cluster of small wires to his body, fixed a brace to measure his chest movement and put a mask on his face—a Continuous Positive Airway Pressure (CPAP)—to blow air at a steady pressure. Hooked up, they asked him to sleep. When he woke up at 5 a.m., he was stunned. He had not felt this fresh since long. A week later, he got the results of his sleep tests—he had stopped breathing 38 times in an hour, had absolutely no Stage 4 type sleep, which refreshes the mind and the body. With the CPAP machine, his breathing became normal and 17 per cent of his sleep was of Stage 4 type. And the diagnosis clearly spelt out—sleep apnea.

He is not alone. Especially, at a time when frenzied corporate culture confuses sleeplessness with vitality and high performance. According to medics, “The biggest trouble with sleep disorders is that most people don’t know

they have it. It’s almost impossible to self-diagnose it. You are unconscious when it happens,” says Dr M.S. Kanwar, who heads the sleep lab at Apollo Hospital, Delhi.

The symptoms: Tired all the time, nodding off in the afternoon—may be too much work, snuffling at night—just a snoring problem. Often irritable—a personality problem. But adventures in sleep labs mask a tougher reality. Kanwar explains, “We snore. Then, we go quiet for a while. Our chest heaves. Nothing happens. Our body tries again. Still nothing happens. Then our brain posts an alarm that without oxygen, it will starve. So our reflexes get our body to function. There’s snuffling, wheezing and then a big intake of breath. This then goes back to normal breathing—or more snoring—until the cycle starts again,” he adds, “and all the while, we are fast asleep, blissfully unaware of whatever is going on.”

“Millions suffer from insomnia and many more from a range of sleep disorders,” says Dr Randeep Guleria of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). Apollo treats about 7 to 10 such cases a week, while the sleep lab of the medicine department at AIIMS attends about 20 new patients.